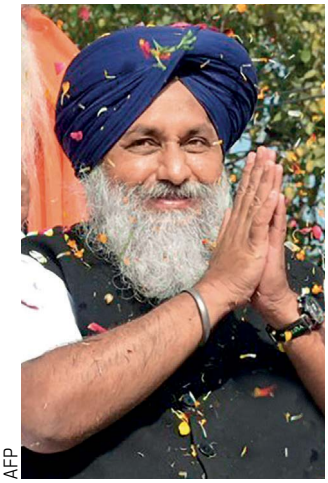


AFP

IN DIRE STRAITS

SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL
President, Shiromani Akali Dal

USP: With the SAD contesting all 13 seats for the first time in 40 years, he's trying to champion the Panthic cause to enthuse the core voter base

But: Still facing a credibility crisis, he has inevitably let radicals fill the vacuum left by the Akalis; is even struggling to retain the family bastions of Bathinda and Ferozepur

THE RADICAL FACES

AMRITPAL SINGH
Independent candidate, Khadoor Sahib

USP: A jailed Khalistan propagandist, he is gaining traction in this Panthic seat. Has got the backing of the radical **Simranjit Singh Mann**, who too is defending his Sangrur seat

But: Khadoor Sahib could see a split in Panthic vote with the Akali Dal fielding **Virsa Singh Valtoha**, a former close aide of Bhindranwale



PRABHJOT GILL



SARABJIT SINGH KHALSA
Independent candidate, Faridkot

USP: Is seeking votes in the name of his father Beant Singh, the Indira Gandhi assassin feted among radicals

But: Lacks resources of an established party to run his campaign

Pannun. Meanwhile, in Faridkot, Sarabjit Singh Khalsa—son of Beant Singh, one of the two bodyguards who had assassinated the then prime minister Indira Gandhi in 1984—is contesting as an Independent. In 1989, at the peak of militancy, his mother Bimal Kaur and grandfather Sucha Singh were also elected MPs from Ropar and Bathinda, respectively. Sarabjit, too, had made unsuccessful attempts from Bathinda (2004) as a SAD (Amritsar) nominee and from Fatehgarh Sahib (2014) as a Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) candidate. "This time," he tells INDIA TODAY, "there is a palpable sentiment to regain Sikh pride, and people are looking for a new leadership."

Like Sarabjit, both Simranjit and Amritpal are gaining significant traction in their constituencies. Simranjit's stunning victory in the 2022 Sangrur bypoll—necessitated after the seat was vacated by Bhagwant Mann to enter the state legislature—was aided by the rise of radicalism and anger against the newly elected AAP government over a series of missteps and the killing of singer Sidhu Moosewala by gangsters. In his current campaign, the sitting MP is again raking up issues pushed by the radicals, such as the release of Sikh militants and justice in the 2015 sacrilege events. Other legacy issues like the transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab and the return of Punjabi-speaking areas from Haryana and Himachal Pradesh also find mention. Although Amritpal has not managed to get interim bail to campaign, his followers are raising similar issues while demanding his release. But his contest with Valtoha could end up benefitting their rivals. For, in the past two general elections, the split in the Panthic vote has seen the Congress gain space and acceptance in Khadoor Sahib—the seat is presently held by the party's Jasbir Singh Gill, the first-ever leader to have captured it without any Panthic credentials.

Traditionally, the SAD has been the custodian of the Panthic agenda, with credit going to Parkash Singh Badal for keeping radicals at bay over the past three decades. However, his son is fighting a battle for survival. Most political observers believe Sukhbir's head will be on the chopping block if the party fails to improve upon its 2022 assembly election's vote share of 18.4 per cent. Sukhbir's challenges are compounded by his former allies. The BSP, which had joined hands with the Akalis for the state election two years ago, is now contesting separately. And the BJP, with whom the SAD had a fallout over the now-repealed farm laws, has lassoed in some influential Akali loyalists—for instance, the family of Sukhbir's close aide Sikander Singh Maluka, whose daughter-in-law Parampal Kaur Sidhu is the BJP candidate from Bathinda. Another close aide, Ravikaran Singh Kahlon, has also crossed over to the saffron fold, while the party's Dalit face in Doaba, Pawan Kumar Tinu, is now the AAP's Jalandhar candidate, eroding Sukhbir's support among the Ravidasi/ Ramdasi community as well.

A weakened Akali Dal is thus allowing radicals to fill the political vacuum. On May 26, after repeated complaints from Valtoha, Sukhbir was forced to expel his brother-in-law Adesh Partap Singh Kairon for allegedly working